party... this is being done by a section of rootless so-called BJP workers who are not aligned to the party's ideology and policies... the recent incident in which my name is being dragged is part of that same conspiracy to destroy senior and old party workers," read the letter.

Meanwhile, the suicide-turned-job scam has expectedly triggered a political slugfest between the Opposition parties and the ruling BJP in the state. On August 24, Congress women leaders met Governor Gulab Chand Kataria and demanded strict punishment against the guilty. The party has alleged that the circumstances leading to Indrani's suicide exposed a "ring of corruption" in the present BJP-led Assam government.

CM Sarma rubbishes such criticism, saying that the incident, in fact, indirectly affirms the robustness and transparency of the recruitment processes in the state. "Nobody who allegedly paid money to the accused could get a job. This itself proves that the recruitment process was free from any malpractice. This incident has confirmed our repeated assertions that the youth in the state are getting government jobs based on merit and without paying a single penny to anyone," Sarma told INDIA TODAY. Police sources also claim that none of the candidates whose admit cards were recovered from Chaliha's home could secure any government job.

Despite a tough stand in front of the media, the BJP state unit has taken these developments very seriously. In fact, Indrani's suicide was on top of the agenda at the party's core committee meeting held at Guwahati's Vajpayee Bhawan on August 28. The meeting, chaired by Kalita, was attended by Sarma and Union minister Sarbananda Sonowal, among others. Certainly, the scar of corruption has been the first major embarrassment that Sarma has faced in his tenure of two years. ■



**NEW ROLE?**
Bihar CM Nitish Kumar

ANI

UTTAR PRADESH

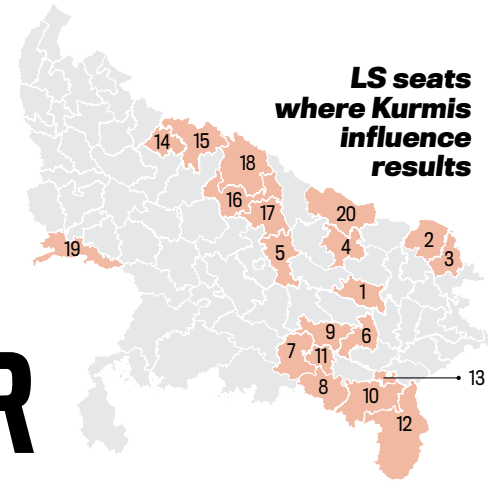
# THE KURMI FACTOR

**By Prashant Srivastava**

It all started last September after Janata Dal (United) president Lalan Singh said in an interview that the people of Uttar Pradesh wanted Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar to champion their cause in the Lok Sabha. About two months ago, that spark caught fire among members of his community, the Kurmis—the second-largest grouping after the Yadavs among the OBC community in the state. Soon, almost every media outlet was speculating about how the Bihar CM would contest the Phulpur Lok Sabha seat as a candidate of the opposition 'INDIA' alliance in 2024. The state's main Opposition, the Samajwadi Party (SP) and a Kurmi consolidation, the Apna Dal (K), also endorsed the idea.

Phulpur, in eastern UP, is considered a Kurmi-dominated seat. It was said that if Nitish was to decide to contest from here, it would set the tone for the Opposition in UP, which sends 80 MPs to the Lok Sabha. The Kurmis, who reportedly make up around 8 per cent of the state's population, could influence the result in at least two dozen LS seats.

But then, just when the rumour was getting wings, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited the home of




*1.* Ambedkar Nagar *2.* Maharajganj *3.* Kushi Nagar *4.* Gonda *5.* Barabanki *6.* Jaunpur *7.* Kaushambi *8.* Prayagraj *9.* Pratapgarh *10.* Mirzapur *11.* Phulpur *12.* Robertsganj *13.* Varanasi *14.* Bareilly *15.* Pilibhit *16.* Dhaurara *17.* Sitapur *18.* Kheri *19.* Fatehpur *20.* Shrawasti

***THERE ARE 41 KURMI MLAs IN THE 403-SEAT UP ASSEMBLY***